University of Essex



Contextual Offers Policy

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We are committed to ensuring that all students with the merit and potential to benefit from an Essex education are supported to do so. We're proud that an Essex education transforms our students lives and equips them with the knowledge and skills to be active, impactful citizens, locally and globally.

Don't just take our word for it. Essex is ranked 12th in the Guardian University Guide 2026. This measures the effectiveness of our teaching and support for students in unlocking the potential of every student: wherever you come from and whatever your background.

What is a contextual offer?

We make contextual offers because we understand your grades can be influenced by a range of factors. A contextual offer is personalised to you and your potential to succeed as an Essex undergraduate student – as well as what you have achieved so far.

If you are eligible for a contextual offer – it may be an offer that is up to two A-level grades, or equivalent, below our standard conditional offer.

Contextual offers will be made to eligible applicants taking A-levels, a Level 3 BTEC Extended Diploma, a combination of qualifications that hold UCAS tariff points (e.g., A-levels alongside a BTEC) and the International Baccalaureate. Where possible, we will make contextual offers to eligible applicants holding other qualifications. If the standard offer is already at the contextual offer equivalent level based on your individual offer conditions or qualifications (e.g. UAL Level 3 Extended Diploma), we may be unable to make you a contextual offer. For further information about what a contextual offer may look like for your specific qualification profile, please contact our Admissions team.

We make contextual offers from underrepresented groups, however, there will be other circumstances and further eligibility criteria are detailed below.

How do I get a contextual offer?

You don't need to do anything to be considered and the application process is the same; submit your application and if you're eligible for a contextual offer, you'll receive information about this in your offer letter.

Please note your offer may contain specific conditions (for example a specific grade in a specific A level or GCSE) and unless specifically stated in your contextual offer, these conditions will still be required for your chosen course.

Does every programme make contextual offers?

Contextual offers are available for most, but not all, of our courses. Some courses may be excluded where specific entry requirements apply, where the standard conditional offer is already set at a level comparable to or lower than a potential contextual offer, or where other course-specific factors, including external, regulatory or partnership restrictions prevent the use of contextual offers.

Contextual offers are not available for the following courses or subject areas:

- East 15 School degrees
- BSc Physiotherapy
- FdSc Dental Hygiene
- Degrees with a foundation year
- LLB Licence English and French Law
- LLB Law Senior Status
- Edge Hotel School degrees
- Therapeutic Communication and Therapeutic Organisations (BA and FdA)
- Certificate of Higher Education in Health and Social Care
- Apprenticeship degrees

Who is eligible for a contextual offer?

Applicants who apply in the 2027 cycle may be made a contextual offer based on one of the following criteria:

Applicants who apply through UCAS from one of the categories below (the information to identify whether an applicant is eligible for a contextual offer on this basis comes to us via the UCAS application form):

- **Estranged**

Students residing in the UK who are estranged from their parents.

- **Young carer**

Students residing in the UK who helped to look after someone in their family who is ill, disabled, has a mental health condition.

- **Military families**

Students residing in the UK who have a parent or carer serving in the Armed Forces.

- **Refugee/asylum seeker**

Where residing in the UK students with 'refugee status' or 'Humanitarian Protection', and asylum seekers.

- **Free school meal recipients**

Students residing in the UK, who are (or have been) eligible or receiving free school meals during their secondary education.

- **POLAR4 Quintile 1 & 2**

Students residing in the UK where there is low progression to Higher Education, defined as Quintiles 1 and 2 from OFS POLAR4 data.

- **Care experienced**

Students residing in the UK, who have experience of care. This could include students who have spent time living with foster carers under local authority care, in residential care (e.g. a children's home), looked after at home under a supervision order, or in kinship care with relatives or friends, either officially (e.g. a special guardianship order) or informally without local authority support.

- **Disability**

Students residing in the UK who have declared one or more disability type on their application.

Specific applicant criteria are outlined above – in addition some applicants are not eligible. These include:

- second/final year entrants
- recognised transfer programme applicants
- applicants taking vocational or work-based learning qualifications
- applicants taking qualifications graded either 'pass' or 'fail'

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